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Deuteronomy

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Deuteronomy

A. Theme and Background

1. The name of the book comes from the Septuagint (LXX) title of the book meaning “second law”. The intent was that most of the book is not new laws but, a repeating a second time of that which the Lord gave to Moses in the earlier books. There are about 250 references in Deuteronomy to the previous four books of the Pentateuch, also called the Torah, and about 350 references to Deuteronomy in the Old Testament overall. It is referenced 95 times in the New Testament. Jesus quoted from Deuteronomy more times than any of the other books of the Torah. The book covers a period of about one month at the end of Moses’s life (about 1405 BC), when Moses addresses a new generation of Israelites who were the children of those who came out of Egypt but perished in the Wilderness due to their unbelief and rebellion. The Israelites are on plains of Moab, the eastern side of the Jordan River across from Jericho and are poised to enter the Good Land. Moses is now 120 years old and has led his people for the past 40 years.
2. A key verse to the book is found in Deuteronomy 6:12: “be careful that you do not forget the LORD, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery.” The previous generation forgot what the Lord had done for them in bringing them out of Egypt, Moses does not wish that this generation do the same.
3. It can be said that Deuteronomy is a book of love in that the word “love” appears here 21 times. This is because they needed to love the Lord God and realize that it was not all about rules and regulations.
 - a. An example is found in Deuteronomy 6:4-6 “Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one! You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength. And these words which I command you today shall be in your heart.” This lacer verse comprises what is called the “Shema” meaning “hear” or “listen” and is considered to be the most essential prayer of Judaism today.
 - b. God’s intention has always been that we hide His Words in our hearts so that we do not sin against Him (Psalm 119:11). The Hebrew word translated “one” here emphasizes monotheism in a pagan land of many gods but also conveys “unity”.

The same word is used in Genesis 2:24 where a man shall cleave to his wife and they shall be “one” flesh. In this word, we can see the Trinity.

4. The book is comprised of three farewell speeches given by Moses. One looks to the past, one to the present and one to the future. In chapters 1-3, Moses reviews the past. In chapters 4-26 there are regulations for the present for obedience in love in 27 through 34, readiness for the future.

B. Chapters 1-3 are historical where Moses reminds the Children of Israel what God has done.

1. In verse 1:2, Moses notes that it is 11 days journey from Horeb (Mt Sinai) to Kadesh Barnea, the entrance point to the Good Land, to remind them that it took their parents 38 years due to their unbelief and rebellion.
2. In verses 1:6-8, Moses reminds them of what God said about staying long enough at Horeb, and to move forward and possess the land that He has given them. Some have calculated that the area promised by God to them was about 480,000 square kilometers. But at the pinnacle of Israel’s kingdom under David and Solomon, they only possessed 48,000 square miles or 1/10th of what God had promised them.
3. In verses 1:19-46 Moses reviews that spies were sent into the Good Land but that their parents rebelled against going in and were given a death curse. Estimates are that the children of Israel numbered over 1.2 million at that point and all but two died in the wilderness. Over 40 years, that would be about 80 deaths per day or a constant reminder that the wages of sin is death (Romans 6:23).

C. Chapters 2 and 3 record the places they had been and armies they had defeated.

D. Chapters 4 through 26 contain the second farewell speech of Moses, comprised of the regulations for the Israelites during the present. The transition is from the past remembrance to what is happening now for them.

1. Moses admonishes the Israelites not to add or take away from God’s commands (4:2). God does not want His Word to be changed or taken away (Revelation 22:18-19). Today, many pick out of the Bible verses that support a particular viewpoint of theirs and ignore the rest or twist them.
2. The Ten Commandments given in Exodus chapter 20 are reiterated and expanded upon in Deuteronomy chapters 5-11.

3. Chapters 12 -16:16 cover ceremonial law.
4. Chapters 16:17-20 cover civil law. In 18:15 is a prophecy of the Messiah: "The LORD your God will raise up for you a Prophet like me from among your midst, from your brethren. You must listen to him." Some Islamic clerics have accepted to tie this prophecy to Mohammad but note the verse says that this prophet will arise from among your brethren not from among the Arabs. In John 1:21, John the Baptist is asked if he is Elijah. When he denies it, they ask if he is the Prophet in reference to this passage in Deuteronomy. Philip testifies "we have found the one Moses writes about in the Law" (John 1:45) also referring to this same prophecy.
5. Chapter 21-26 pertain to social laws.

E. Chapter 27 to the end of the book is the last farewell address by Moses.

1. Chapter 27 records that Moses instructed the Israelites that after they entered the Good Land, tribes were to stand on Mount Ebal to pronounce the curses and other tribes were to stand on Mount Gerizim to pronounce the blessings written in this chapter. It is interesting that those tribes on Ebal included Dan which was the first tribe to lead Israel into idolatry. Dan is also not listed in Revelation chapter 7 with the other tribes. A recent archeological discovery taken from Mount Ebal is a folded lead scroll on which was written a curse dating from this period.
2. Chapter 28 opens with a big "if" you will fully obey your God, He will give you many blessings. The chapter closes with a warning against disobedience with curses and a prophetic word about the nation being taken away captive by Babylon. This was a conditional covenant based upon both parties meeting the demands.
3. Chapter 29 is a renewal of the covenant God made with the Israelites at Mt Sinai.
4. Chapter 30 is a promise that if they return to the Lord, He will bless them in the land He will give them.
5. Chapter 31 describes how Joshua is to be appointed leader after Moses dies.
6. Chapter 32 records the very long song of Moses and instructions for him to go to Mount Nebo to die.
7. Chapter 33 records Moses' blessings to the tribes.

8. Chapter 34 records the death of Moses. God shows him the Good Land which is denied to him due to his disobedience. He dies and God buries him in a valley opposite Beth Peor but no one knows the location to this day. In the New Testament, the book of Jude verse 9 says that the archangel Michael disputed with Satan over the body of Moses. At the transfiguration of Jesus (Matthew 17:1-3) Moses and Elijah are there talking with Him. They represent the Law and the Prophets. Although Moses was denied entry into the Good Land at his death, he arrives here. It can be said that although the Law failed, Grace prevailed!

F. Discussion questions, application and passing it on.

1. Is there something in your past where you resisted or rebelled against God's instruction to you? Have you been wandering in the wilderness? What are you going to do about it?
2. In chapter one the Lord tells them that they have been too long at Mount Horeb. Have you stayed too long at a certain place? Maybe not necessarily geographical but perhaps spiritually? Has He said to you that you have been subsisting too long on milk, it is time for solid food (1 Corinthians 3:2)?
3. The Israelites only appropriated 1/10th of what God had promised to them. Are you appropriating all of the exceeding great and precious promises God has given us in Scripture so that you can partake of His divine nature to escape the corruption of the world (2 Peter 1:4)?
4. Moses' second farewell speech transitions from the past to the Israelites present. We too must remember the past of what God has done in our lives but, apply that to the present. Do you linger in your thoughts to what your early Christian life was, or the good experiences you may have had in church, or do you apply what you have learned to the present? Is your experience of Him as fresh and as vibrant today as it may have been in the past?
5. When Jesus was asked what is the greatest commandment (Matthew 22:36)? He responded with Deuteronomy 6:5: "Love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul and with all your strength" and coupled it with the second from Leviticus 19:18: Love your neighbor as yourself." Jesus went on to say that on these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets (Matthew 22:37-40). Can you truthfully say that you are obeying these two commandments?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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